

Conceptualizing and Improving Creator Moderation Design with Platform Stakeholders

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ABSTRACT

My doctoral research aims to conceptualize and improve creator moderation design based on (1) content creators' voice and (2) multiple platform stakeholders' collaboration. Four of our previous publications in the CSCW conferences have uncovered the socioeconomic impacts of moderation on creators, as well as the fairness and bureaucracy challenges they undertake, implicating the transparency design requirements for addressing these challenges. Two of proposed future studies will pivot into evaluating and refining creator moderation design with different platform stakeholders. First, I will explore how audiences and creators recognize creator moderation's compatibility with platform ecosystem (e.g., monetization, recommendation algorithms). Second, I will organize participatory design workshops with stakeholders such as creators, commercial moderators, and audiences to redesign creator moderation to balance different stakeholders' stakes and platform's top-down moderation efforts. My dissertation aims to contribute to HCI and CSCW fields through the notion of creator moderation and comprehensive design and policy solutions for a safe and sustaining platform ecosystem.

CCS CONCEPTS

• Human-centered computing; • Collaborative and social computing;

KEYWORDS

creator moderation, content moderation, content creators

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1 RESEARCH SITUATION

At the time of CSCW 2023's doctoral consortium, I am a fourth-year, full-time Ph.D. candidate in the Informatics Ph.D. program at The Pennsylvania State University's College of Information Sciences

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and Technology, where I am advised by Dr. Yubo Kou. The themes of my research are HCI, CSCW, and, particularly, creator moderation.

2 RESEARCH MOTIVATION

In recent years, the “creator economy” has emerged, where independent content creators rely on platforms such as YouTube, Twitch, Instagram, and TikTok to build up their fanbase, earn different types of income (e.g., ads, fan donation), and establish content creation as a profession. With over 50 million people identifying themselves as creators and two million making content creation their full-time job [7], creators aim to establish their branding and make themselves competitive and distinguishable from other creators to sustain their careers [8, 24]. It is also common that creators work across platforms to diversify their income and creativity [11, 26].

However, being a creator does not guarantee absolute freedom in content creation, and monetizing content does not ensure secure self-employment. Creators must ensure that their content does not violate platform-specific content policies, or they may face creator moderation [20, 21], where multiple governance mechanisms exercise control over the creators' careers, including their income [5] and visibility [4]. Unfortunately, creator moderation often negatively impacts creators, as seen in instances where advertising income is unfairly reduced for creators from racial and sexual minority groups [1, 2].

Similarly, HCI and CSCW researchers have gained much knowledge of how general social media users experience content moderation. For example, users are confused about moderation decision-making [10], feel unfair about its decisions [14, 28], or have a hard time appealing moderation decisions [16]. However, at the time when I started my doctoral research, there were still research gaps in understanding how content creators experience moderation and how their experiences make a difference from the ones of general social media users. So, I put forward the first, exploratory research question in my doctoral research:

RQ1: How do content creators experience creator moderation?

When considering a multi-stakeholder perspective on moderation, it is not sufficient to focus solely on the binary relationship between platform and creator. Instead, it is important to acknowledge that users with different online roles may have varying experiences with moderation. For instance, legal scholars may interpret across-regions content rules as having implications for privacy or safety breaches [6]. The use of friends as human moderators may raise privacy concerns for these individuals [23]. In addition, content creators on YouTube have expressed confusion and frustration with a new moderation design aimed at protecting children's privacy, which has resulted in many false positives (i.e., harmful content for kids) [17, 18]. Given these varied perspectives, my second research question seeks to ask:

RQ2: How do platform stakeholders evaluate creator moderation design?

Along with the efforts of understanding how users experience or interact with moderation design, HCI and CSCW researchers have also strived to design fairer, more transparent, and contestable moderation mechanisms (e.g., [9, 15, 28, 30]). But it remains unknown whether and how these moderation design structures fit creators' workflows. The commonly discussed moderation designs are those directly impacting content, such as removing a video that contains hateful speech. But compared to content moderation, creator moderation is more related to its synergy and intersections with parts of platform ecosystem, such as recommendation or monetization algorithms. However, under this context, we have relatively limited knowledge of how moderation could better work with different platform stakeholders, such as creators, commercial moderators, and audiences, to balance their stakes with platform's top-down, authoritative moderation force. So, my third research question is:

RQ3: How can creator moderation design better work with platform stakeholders?

3 WORK TO DATE

My work has answered RQ1 but has yet to fully answer RQ2 and RQ3. With four publications from CSCW 2021 to 2023 [19–22], I have conducted a series of studies to gain an initial understanding of creator moderation on YouTube, as YouTube is currently the largest video-sharing platform and among the first to allow users to monetize their content [13]. In the following two subsections, I will detail how my published work and proposed studies address the research questions sequentially.

3.1 Study 1 → RQ1: Experiencing Creator Moderation's Socioeconomic Impacts

In the very first study [19], we explore what creator moderation is and especially creators' experiences with it, partially addressing RQ1. Using a thematic analysis of online discussion data from the r/youtube subreddit, one of the largest YouTube-related online communities, we found that creator moderation has socioeconomic impacts on creators beyond content-level moderation. The algorithmic opacity of moderation decisions on YouTube, which is largely implemented through machine learning algorithms, results in precarity for creators in their video creation work. As a result, creators strive to cope with this precarity by gaining knowledge of creator moderation and diversifying their income through multiple crowdfunding platforms. This study provides a foundation for further exploration into how creators navigate and make sense of creator moderation design.

3.2 Study 2 → RQ1: Encountering Fairness and Bureaucracy Challenges

In the second case study, we sought to acquire in-depth knowledge of creators' moderation experience, which oftentimes challenges their creativity and career development. To do so, we conducted 28 semi-structured interviews with creators who had experienced moderation on YouTube, which allowed us to fully answer RQ1. Our findings suggest that creators generate a sense of fairness perception based on the different contexts of moderation decisions they

receive [20]. Specifically, we found that creators perceive unfairness when they encounter unequal moderation treatments, inconsistent decisions, processes, or system actions, and when they feel that their voices are not involved in algorithmic visibility decision-making processes.

Moreover, we found that creators on YouTube encounter algorithmic and organizational bureaucracy during the moderation process [21]. First, creators experience algorithmic bureaucracy when YouTube's moderation system fails to adapt to their novel and localized content. Second, creators experience organizational bureaucracy, where they are not in a privileged position to appeal moderation decisions.

3.3 Study 3 → RQ3: Transparency Design of Creator Moderation

Prior research has emphasized the importance of transparency in addressing bureaucracy [25] and fairness [3, 29] challenges. Building on this understanding, we [22] examine the role of transparency in creator moderation on YouTube and how it can be designed to address creators' concerns and support their learning about moderation, partially answering RQ3. Across the phases of creator moderation, we identify four key elements that creators desire in a transparent moderation system: salient presentation of moderation decisions, profound explanations of moderation rationales, effective communication with human agents (e.g., human reviewers, creator support team), and design affordances for learning opportunities. We emphasize the need for dynamic moderation transparency that balances the benefits of transparency with the potential negative impacts on creators' labor. Our study sheds light on the importance of transparency in creator moderation and provides practical recommendations for designing transparent moderation systems that meet creators' voice and needs.

4 PROPOSED WORK: PLATFORM STAKEHOLDERS IN CREATOR MODERATION

In my future dissertation work, I will pivot into understanding how multiple platform stakeholders such as audiences, commercial moderators, and creators evaluate moderation design and how to balance different platform stakeholders' stakes and platform's top-down moderation efforts through Studies 4 and 5 to fully answer RQ2 and RQ3.

4.1 Study 4 → RQ2: Evaluating Creator Moderation Design with Multi-Stakeholder Perspectives

I will conduct a qualitative study by (1) analyzing online discussions posted by audiences and audiences who are also creators and (2) interviewing stakeholders such as commercial moderators and even advertisers to understand how they evaluate creator moderation design and how it plays a role in their goal and activity on the platform like YouTube.

The expected findings of this study will be (1) evaluative criteria of how creator moderation design meets the goal of preventing abusive and facilitating online community cooperation [12], (2)

creators' practices and reactions to content policy enforcement, (3) the perceived utility and effectiveness of creator moderation design from audiences, creators, and commercial moderators, and (4) viewpoints of how creator moderation design is compatible with the platform ecosystem (e.g., monetization, recommendation algorithms).

4.2 Study 5 → RQ2 and 3: Co-designing Creator Moderation with Platform Stakeholders

As creator moderation essentially functions with and influences different platform stakeholders such as creators, commercial moderators, and audiences (e.g., parents), I aim to conduct participatory design (PD) [27] workshops to systematically elicit a better design of creator moderation across different stakeholders' perspectives. This study will fully answer RQ3. The PD workshop procedure includes identifying platform stakeholders with certain inclusion criteria, material preparation, exploration of work, co-design activity, and evaluation activity with focus group discussion. I expect that co-designing with them can generate a common ground conceptualization of creator moderation as well as design and policy solutions to reconcile different stakeholders' conflicts with the platform.

5 CONTRIBUTIONS

My doctoral research aims to offer three primary contributions to the HCI and CSCW fields. To start, my research provides a comprehensive definition for understanding the concept of creator moderation, which fills a gap in the existing research of content moderation in CSCW. Second, I will contextualize different stakeholders' voice and roles in creator moderation and offer design guidelines for them. Last, since HCI research places significant importance on advocating for end-users, my study offers policy and design implications to empower different platform stakeholders under creator moderation.

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